



DETERMINERS

The words that introduce and clarify a noun

1 What is it?

Determiners (dih-TUR-min-erz)

A determiner is a word placed before a noun to clarify what it refers to — such as which one, whose it is, or how many there are.

comes before + a noun to clarify it

2 See it in action

Articles

"**The** dog barked at **a** cat."

Possessive

"**My** coat is warmer than **your** jacket."

Demonstrative

"**This** pen works, but **that** one doesn't."

Quantifier

"**Some** people brought **several** snacks."



Think about...

Spot every 'the', 'a' and 'an' in a paragraph first — articles are the most common type of determiner by far.

3 More to know

Numbers

"She read **three** books and borrowed **another**."

Indefinite quantifier

"**Every** student needs **enough** time to finish."

FUN FACT

"The" is the single most commonly used word in the entire English language, appearing roughly once in every 20 words of typical written text.

4 Why it's used

Determiners help: tell the reader exactly which noun is being talked about, how many there are, or who it belongs to, before the noun even appears.

The three articles (a, an, the) are the most common determiners, but possessives (my, your, their), demonstratives (this, that) and quantifiers (some, many, few) are determiners too.



Look here!

Check whether a noun follows immediately after a word like 'this' or 'that' — if it does, it's working as a determiner, not a pronoun.

5 Don't mix it up

DETERMINERS

A determiner sits before a noun to introduce or clarify it — "this book", "my book".

A PRONOUN

A pronoun replaces the noun entirely rather than introducing it — "this" alone, or "it", standing in for "the book".

⚠ Watch out!

"This", "that", "these" and "those" can act as either a determiner ("this book") OR a pronoun ("this is mine") — the difference is whether a noun follows immediately after.

6 Quick recap

Introduces a noun

Includes articles a/an/the

Clarifies which/whose/how many



Good spot!

Possessive determiners (my, your, their, our) always answer the question 'whose?' about the noun that follows.